

75+ Years of Indian Politics and Development: Why Has India's Development Remained Uneven?

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Introduction

India has been an independent country for more than 75 years. During this period, India has changed significantly. From a country struggling with poverty, food shortages, low industrial development and limited public services, India has become one of the major economies of the world. We have seen growth in industries, roads, education, healthcare, information technology, digital payments and communication.

However, when we look beyond the national statistics, a different picture can also be seen. Development has not reached every part of India equally. Some states and cities have developed much faster than others. There are still major differences between rural and urban areas and between people from different economic and social backgrounds.

This raises an important question: if India has developed so much after independence, why do so many people still face unemployment, poor-quality education, healthcare problems and insecure employment?

This is the main question I have tried to understand through this report.

I have used secondary sources from organisations such as the World Bank, UNDP, NITI Aayog, International Labour Organization, IMF, NFHS and World Inequality Database. The purpose is not to say that every government has either succeeded or failed, but to understand how political decisions, economic policies, social conditions and their implementation have affected India's development.

India's Development Journey After Independence

To understand India's present situation, we first need to look at where the country started.

India became independent in 1947 after experiencing colonial exploitation, widespread poverty and limited industrial development. The Partition also created enormous social and economic difficulties. At the same time, India had to establish a democratic system for a huge and diverse population.

Therefore, I do not think it would be fair to compare present-day India directly with India in 1947 without considering how difficult the starting conditions were.

During the first decades after independence, the government focused strongly on nation-building. Five-Year Plans, public-sector industries, infrastructure, scientific institutions and large development projects were

given importance. This helped create an industrial and scientific base for the country. However, the economy was also highly controlled, with many licences and restrictions that sometimes slowed decision-making and private investment.

The Green Revolution later became one of India's major achievements. Better seeds, irrigation, fertilisers, agricultural research and government procurement helped increase food production. This was especially important because India had faced serious food shortages. However, the benefits were greater in regions that already had better irrigation, credit, land and market access. This was an early example of a pattern that continued later: a policy could be successful at the national level while producing unequal results across different regions.

The 1991 economic crisis became another major turning point. India introduced liberalisation and opened the economy more to private investment and international trade. Sectors such as information technology, telecommunications, finance and services expanded rapidly.

Economic reforms helped India grow faster, but growth alone did not solve problems related to agriculture, informal employment, education, healthcare and regional inequality.

After 2004, greater attention was given to welfare programmes, rural employment and basic services. More recently, India has focused heavily on infrastructure, digital connectivity, financial inclusion, direct benefit transfers, manufacturing and digital public systems. These changes have created many new opportunities, but several basic problems still remain.

Why Has Development Remained Uneven?

In my opinion, there is no single reason behind India's uneven development. Several factors are connected with each other.

Politics and Implementation

India has a federal political system where both the central government and state governments have important responsibilities. This can be an advantage because states can develop policies according to their local needs. However, different states have different administrative capacities.

A state with better schools, hospitals, roads, government offices and trained officials may implement a national scheme much more effectively than a state where these systems are weaker.

Political competition can also encourage governments to work for people because they have to answer to voters. At the same time, elections can sometimes encourage governments to focus on projects that produce visible results quickly instead of long-term improvements such as teacher training, healthcare systems and institutional reforms.

Therefore, the problem is not always a lack of government schemes. Sometimes the bigger problem is implementation.

A policy may look very good on paper but fail to produce its intended results because of delays, corruption, weak administration, poor coordination or the absence of effective grievance systems.

Economic Growth and Employment

India's economic growth is undoubtedly an important achievement. Poverty has also declined significantly. But poverty reduction does not necessarily mean that every family has become financially secure.

Someone may move above an international poverty line but still have an unstable job, low income, debt or difficulty paying for healthcare and education.

This makes employment one of India's most important challenges.

India has a very large young population, but many workers are still employed in informal, low-paying or insecure jobs. The growth of high-skilled industries such as information technology is useful, but these sectors alone cannot provide employment to everyone.

India therefore needs employment opportunities at different skill levels. Manufacturing, food processing, tourism, construction, logistics, agriculture-related industries, small businesses and repair services can all play an important role.

Income and Social Inequality

Another major reason for uneven development is inequality in income and wealth.

People who already have access to good education, land, finance, professional networks and better urban opportunities are often able to benefit more from economic growth.

Social factors also influence development. Caste, gender, location, disability, language and family background can affect a person's access to education, employment, land, credit and government services.

For example, two children may both be officially enrolled in school. But one may have a good school, trained teachers, internet access, proper nutrition and family support, while another may live in a remote area with poor transport, limited internet and fewer educational resources.

Both children are technically receiving education, but their actual opportunities are very different.

The same problem can be seen in healthcare. India has improved areas such as institutional births, sanitation and healthcare coverage, but nutrition, anaemia and the quality of public healthcare still vary significantly between regions.

Regional and Rural-Urban Differences

One of the clearest examples of uneven development is the difference between states.

National averages can hide important regional differences. According to the NITI Aayog SDG India Index discussed in the original report, India's overall development indicators have improved, but differences between states still remain.

Some states have benefited from earlier investments in education, healthcare, industries, cities, ports and administrative systems. Other states continue to face combinations of low income, weaker public services, limited industrial development and employment pressure.

As someone from Jharkhand, I find this particularly important. Development cannot be understood only by looking at India's GDP. We also need to ask what development actually looks like in individual districts, villages and smaller towns.

The rural-urban divide is another important issue. Cities generally provide more employment, universities, hospitals, markets and other opportunities. However, they also face problems such as expensive housing, congestion and informal settlements.

Rural India has improved in areas such as roads, electricity, mobile phones and welfare connections. But many rural families still depend heavily on agriculture or migration for their income.

Digital connectivity is another good example. Having internet access can create opportunities, but internet access alone does not guarantee good education, employment or digital literacy. A person may have a smartphone but still lack the skills or resources to use technology productively.

Institutions, Corruption and Administration

I do not think corruption alone explains India's development problems. The larger issue is the strength and efficiency of institutions.

Consider an ordinary person who needs a land record, pension, hospital service or government benefit. If that person has to visit several offices, wait for months or depend on a middleman, then even a well-designed government scheme becomes less useful.

Strong institutions need simple procedures, transparency, proper auditing, public participation and trained officials.

Technology has improved several government services. Digital records and direct benefit transfers can make certain processes faster and reduce some leakages.

But technology is not a complete solution.

Putting a process online does not automatically make it fair or accessible. People still need accountable officials, grievance systems and offline alternatives.

This is especially important because not everyone has a smartphone, reliable internet or sufficient digital literacy. Development should not create a new digital divide while trying to solve an older one.

Economic Growth vs Human Development

One of the most important questions I found while studying this topic is: **development for whom?**

GDP is an important indicator because it shows the size and growth of economic activity. But GDP cannot tell us everything about people's lives.

GDP cannot tell us whether a child is receiving proper nutrition, whether a student is actually learning, whether a graduate can find a decent job or whether a patient can afford proper treatment.

This is why the idea of human development is important. Development should increase people's opportunities and capabilities, not simply increase economic output.

India needs economic growth because growth creates government revenue, investment, technology and employment opportunities. But economic growth alone is not enough.

If the economy grows while good jobs remain limited, public schools remain weak and healthcare remains unaffordable, the benefits of that growth will not reach everyone equally.

Therefore, India needs both economic growth and strong social foundations.

Politics, Media and Development

As a BJMC student, I believe development is also closely connected with communication and journalism.

Governments and political parties use different slogans and narratives to communicate their development priorities. Examples include "Garibi Hatao", "India Shining", "Digital India", "Make in India", "Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas" and "Viksit Bharat".

Political communication can be useful because it makes people aware of government programmes and national priorities. But communication can also simplify complicated realities.

This is where journalism becomes important.

A journalist should not simply repeat what a government says. Journalism should explain what a scheme actually does, who can benefit from it, how people can apply and what they can do if something goes wrong.

For example, if a government announces a new road, a journalist should not only report the announcement. They should also check whether the road was actually constructed, whether it is being maintained and whether local people are benefiting from it.

The same approach should be applied to schools, hospitals, employment programmes and digital services.

In my opinion, balanced political journalism does not mean supporting or opposing a political party. It means checking political claims against evidence and showing the public what is actually happening.

My Suggestions for More Inclusive Development

From my perspective, India does not need to choose between economic growth and welfare. Both are necessary. The real challenge is connecting economic development with people's everyday lives.

First, India needs to improve the quality of education. Getting children into schools is important, but we also need to focus on what they actually learn. Reading, writing, mathematics, digital literacy, communication and problem-solving skills should be strengthened. Teachers need proper training and students need access to libraries, local-language learning materials, career guidance and practical opportunities.

Second, India needs more productive jobs. Employment should not depend only on agriculture or high-skilled technology sectors. Manufacturing, food processing, tourism, textiles, renewable energy, construction, logistics and small businesses can provide jobs to people with different educational backgrounds. Small businesses should also receive easier access to credit, markets, electricity and transport.

Third, health and women's participation need greater attention. Good healthcare, nutrition, clean water and childcare are important parts of economic development. Women need safe transport, workplace security, childcare, skills and equal employment opportunities. India cannot achieve its full potential if a large section of its population cannot participate fully in the economy.

Fourth, regional inequality needs to be reduced. Poorer states and districts require support, but simply providing money is not enough. Local governments also need stronger institutions and better implementation. Successful policies from one state can be studied and adapted elsewhere according to local conditions.

Fifth, government schemes should become easier to understand. Information about eligibility, budgets, beneficiaries, delays and complaints should be easily available at the district level. Digital platforms can improve access, but offline options must remain available.

Finally, India needs better development communication. Government communication should explain both achievements and limitations. Journalists should also report development carefully by checking facts, speaking to people and examining actual outcomes rather than simply reporting announcements.

Conclusion

After studying India's development journey, I do not think it would be correct to say that India has failed after 75 years.

India has made major progress since independence. It has improved food security, reduced extreme poverty, expanded infrastructure and connectivity, developed industries and services, increased access to welfare programmes and developed strong capabilities in technology and digital systems.

At the same time, it would also be wrong to say that India's development has been completely successful.

Development has not reached every state, district, village or social group equally. Problems related to education quality, healthcare, employment, income inequality and administrative capacity still remain.

Therefore, I would describe India's development as **substantial but uneven and incomplete**.

For me, development should not be judged only by GDP, highways, large buildings or digital transactions. We should also ask some basic questions.

Does a child receive proper nutrition and a good education?

Can a young person find a decent and stable job?

Can a woman safely participate in the economy?

Can a farmer survive a difficult agricultural season?

Can a poor person access a government service without depending on a middleman?

Can a poorer district provide the same basic opportunities as a richer district?

These questions give us a better understanding of what development actually means.

India's next stage of development therefore requires more than economic growth. It requires better education, healthcare, productive employment, stronger local institutions, reduced regional inequality and honest public communication.

As a BJMC student, I also believe journalism has an important role in this process. Journalists should not simply report government announcements. They should go to the ground, talk to people, verify data and find out whether development is actually reaching them.

In the end, India's story is neither a story of complete failure nor a story of complete success. India has moved forward considerably, but the next challenge is to make sure that this progress reaches more people and more places.

The real goal should not only be **development of India**, but **development for all sections of India**.

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